
LEOPARD GECKO

Eublepharis Macularius



Beginner

Complete Care Package

Quick Profile · Care Guide · Health · Quick Reference · Owner Tools

BeastlyFacts

Practical care guides for curious animal lovers

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How to Use This Package

This package is a practical owner manual, not a textbook. Read the Quick Profile and Care Guide once to understand the setup. Then use the checklists, temperature targets, and symptom reference as working tools.

It is written for beginners and intermediate keepers who want clear standards without fluff. It is not a substitute for a reptile-experienced veterinarian. If your gecko shows red-flag symptoms, use the symptom table as a triage aid and contact a vet.

Best use: print the high-action pages and keep the rest as your offline reference.

Print these first

- Temperature Quick Targets - page 11
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Quick rule: correct belly heat, a working moist hide, and safe substrate prevent most beginner problems.

1. Quick Profile

Found across arid regions from Pakistan to northwestern India, leopard geckos are ground-dwelling lizards that shelter in rocky outcrops and dry grasslands by day. Unlike most geckos, they have true eyelids and lack toe pads, so they cannot climb glass. They are among the most widely kept reptile pets, with a huge range of color morphs in captivity.

Native Range	Pakistan, Afghanistan, Iran, India, Nepal
Natural Habitat	Rocky desert, arid grassland, dry scrubland
Adult Size	7-11 inches (18-28 cm)
Diet	Strict insectivore - live insects only
Typical Lifespan	15-20+ years with good care
Conservation	Least Concern (IUCN)
Difficulty	Beginner

Fun Facts

- Unlike most geckos, leopard geckos have true eyelids and can blink.
 - Fat is stored in the tail - a healthy adult should have a plump, rounded tail.
 - They lack sticky toe pads, so they cannot climb glass.
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Cost Overview

A proper one-time setup typically runs \$250-400 before the gecko. That covers a 36x18x18 inch enclosure, under-tank heat mat with thermostat, thermometers, three hides (including a moist hide), safe substrate, water dish, and an initial vet exam with fecal check. Ongoing monthly costs usually fall between \$20 and \$50. Standard pet-quality geckos cost about \$20-45; morphs cost more.

2. Full Care Guide

Housing & Enclosure

A 36x18x18 inch enclosure is the current minimum for a single adult. The old 20-gallon standard is now considered inadequate by most experienced keepers. Floor space matters more than height - leopard geckos are terrestrial. Front-opening, well-ventilated enclosures with an escape-proof top are preferred. **Never** house males together, and cohabitation is generally not recommended.



Example leopard gecko enclosure setup

Quick rule: measure warm-hide surface temperature - belly heat is what matters for leopard geckos.

Temperature, Heating & Humidity

Leopard geckos thermoregulate with belly heat. An under-tank heat mat on a quality thermostat is the preferred primary heat source. Target a warm-hide surface temperature of 88-92°F (some keepers run the warm hide surface closer to 90-95°F). Cool side should stay about 72-78°F. A nighttime drop toward 70°F is normal. **Never** run a heat mat without a thermostat.

Provide three hides: a warm dry hide, a cool dry hide, and a moist hide with damp media. The moist hide creates a local high-humidity pocket (often around 70-80% inside the hide) while the overall enclosure stays about 30-40%. That split matters - raising the whole tank to 70% humidity risks respiratory problems. The moist hide is critical for clean sheds.

Low-output UVB is recommended by current reptile veterinary guidance to support calcium metabolism and normal day/night cycles. Use a modest T5 HO 5-6% setup with a low UVI at the gecko's level (about 0.5-1.5 for normally pigmented animals; lower for albino or lighter morphs). This does not replace calcium supplementation.

Substrate & Furnishings

Paper towel or ceramic tile are the safest substrates, especially for beginners, because they eliminate impaction risk. **Never** use calcium sand. Fine loose sand is not a beginner substrate. Experienced keepers sometimes use naturalistic mixes for healthy adults, but that is not the starting point. Provide cork, slate, and low climbing structure. A shallow water dish should always be available. The moist hide needs damp material maintained on a schedule - dry moss does not help a shed.

Handling

Wait 1-2 weeks after bringing a new gecko home, and only start once it is eating normally. Use a two-handed scoop that supports the body and tail base. **Never** grab or lift by the tail - they can drop it. Stay low to the ground. Start with short 5-minute sessions and build toward 10-20 minutes. Evening handling often works better because they are naturally more active then. **Never** handle during shed or within about 48 hours of a large meal.

Handling session checklist

- Settled and eating for 1-2 weeks
- Not in shed; support body and tail base
- **Never** lift by the tail; stop at stress signals

Diet & Feeding

Leopard geckos are strict insectivores - insects only, no fruit or vegetable purees. Staple feeders include dubia roaches, crickets, and black soldier fly larvae (BSFL / calciworms). Mealworms and superworms are occasional options for adults; waxworms are high-fat treats only. **Never** feed wild-caught insects or fireflies.

Gut-load insects 24-48 hours before feeding. Dust with calcium (with D3 more often for juveniles). Keep a shallow dish of plain calcium in the enclosure. Insects must be no larger than the space between the eyes. Evening feedings match their natural activity better.

Feeding Schedule by Age

Age	Frequency	Focus
Hatchling / young	Daily	Tiny prey; calcium w/D3 most feeds
Juvenile	Daily or every 1-2 days	Growing hard; still insect-heavy
Adult	Every 2-4 days	Adjust to body condition; tail plump

Adults with a plump tail do not need daily force-feeding. Thin, stick-like tails with weight loss need a closer look - including possible Crypto - not more waxworms.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

- **Never** start adults in a tiny enclosure and upgrade later - buy adult floor space from day one.
- **Never** run a heat mat without a thermostat.
- **Never** use calcium sand as substrate.
- **Never** skip the moist hide or raise whole-tank humidity instead.
- **Never** lift by the tail.
- **Never** handle during shed or right after a large meal.
- **Never** feed wild-caught insects or fireflies.
- **Never** house males together.

Enrichment

Enrichment means giving your gecko real ways to hide, hunt, dig, and move through structure. It does **not** replace correct belly heat, calcium, moist-hide maintenance, or safe substrate.

Three hides first

Warm dry, cool dry, and a maintained moist hide are foundation, not optional decor. Hides should be snug and cave-like. The moist hide stays damp (often 70-80% inside the hide) while the rest of the enclosure stays about 30-40%.

Hunting and foraging

Tong-feeding, short supervised insect hunts inside the enclosure, and evening feedings are high-value enrichment for this crepuscular hunter. Keep prey correctly sized. **Never** leave large numbers of feeders unsupervised overnight. **Never** use wild-caught insects.

Climbing and dig

Low sturdy branches, cork flats, and stacked slate add routes and cover without needing a tall arboreal build. A dig box can satisfy digging behavior without converting the whole floor to loose substrate. Paper towel or tile stays the safest primary floor for beginners.

Priority order

1. Correct belly heat + all three hides (including moist hide)
2. Feeding and hunting presentation
3. Low climbing structure and visual cover
4. Dig opportunity
5. Light layout novelty last

Enrichment should **never** mean calcium sand, tail-lifting play, handling during shed, or a one-hide setup sold as complete.

3. Health & Common Issues

Most leopard gecko problems are husbandry problems first. Stuck shed is common and usually prevented by a proper moist hide. Metabolic Bone Disease (MBD) is almost entirely preventable with correct belly heat and calcium (low-level UVB can support D3). Cryptosporidiosis (Crypto) is a serious contagious parasite with no reliable cure - quarantine new animals for 60-90 days and get fecal checks. Impaction is usually linked to unsafe substrate or oversized prey. Obesity can come from too many high-fat feeders like waxworms. Annual fecal exams with a reptile-experienced vet are strongly recommended.

Red Flags - Seek Veterinary Care

- Thinning or stick-like tail with weight loss (possible Crypto)
- Leg trembling, soft jaw, or difficulty walking (possible MBD)
- Stuck shed on toes or eyes that does not clear
- Prolonged appetite loss, lethargy, or abnormal stools
- Swelling or foul smell at a dropped-tail stump
- Clicking, wheezing, or open-mouth breathing

What to tell the vet

Bring recent weight, appetite and stool notes, warm-hide temperature, substrate type, UVB setup if present, and when symptoms started. Photos help. Mention any new animals or shared tools.

Quick rule: weight loss with a thinning tail is more urgent than a short appetite dip in an otherwise plump, active gecko.

Stuck Shed (Dysecdysis)

Retained shed is one of the most common leopard gecko problems and one of the most preventable. Old skin that stays on the toes, eyes, or tail tip can constrict circulation and lead to tissue damage or lost digits if ignored.

What to do

- Keep a dedicated moist hide available at all times and check that it stays damp
- After a shed cycle, inspect toes, eyes, and tail tip closely
- If small patches remain, improve the moist hide first
- A short, shallow lukewarm soak can help loosen mild retained shed - then let the gecko rub it off
- See a reptile vet if shed stays tight on toes/eyes, or if swelling or darkening appears

What *not* to do

- **Never** peel or pull dry stuck shed
- **Never** ignore rings of skin around toes or the tail tip
- **Never** raise whole-tank humidity instead of maintaining a moist hide
- **Never** wait through multiple shed cycles hoping a constricting band will fix itself

4. Quick Reference & Checklist

Essential Setup Checklist

- 36x18x18 inch (or larger) enclosure - floor space over height
- Under-tank heat mat + thermostat
- Three hides (warm dry, cool dry, moist)
- Digital thermometer / infrared gun
- Safe substrate (paper towel or tile)
- Shallow water dish
- Calcium dish + dusting calcium (with D3 for juveniles)
- Starter feeders + gut-load food
- Optional low-output UVB (T5 HO 5-6%)
- Initial vet exam + fecal check budget

Temperature Quick Targets

Zone	Target
Warm hide surface	88-92°F (some run 90-95°F)
Cool side	72-78°F
Night	~70°F typical
Enclosure humidity	30-40%
Inside moist hide	~70-80%

Why these temperatures

Warm hide surface: Belly heat drives digestion and activity. Measure the surface where the gecko sits, not air temperature alone.

Cool side: Lets the gecko leave the heat and self-regulate. Without a real cool zone, they cannot escape excess heat.

Moist hide vs whole-tank humidity: Local moisture supports clean sheds. Raising the whole enclosure to moist-hide levels raises respiratory risk.

5. Owner Tools & Decision Guides

Budget Tiers - Setup

Tier	Range	What you get
Functional minimum	\$250-350	36x18x18, heat mat + thermostat, 3 hides, tile/paper, basics
Recommended	\$350-500	Better thermostat, IR gun, low-output UVB, solid decor, initial fecal
Premium	\$500+	PVC enclosure, refined hides/climbing, backup heat, first wellness visit

Shopping List

- 36x18x18 inch (or larger) enclosure
- Under-tank heat mat + thermostat
- Three hides (warm, cool, moist)
- Infrared temperature gun + digital probe
- Safe substrate (paper towel or tile)
- Shallow water dish + calcium dish
- Calcium with D3 + multivitamin
- Starter feeder insects + gut-load food
- Optional low-output UVB fixture + bulb
- Initial vet exam + fecal check budget

First 30 Days Checklist

The first month is about settling, correct heat, and monitoring - not heavy handling.

- Days 1-3: Minimal handling. Confirm warm-hide surface temp with an infrared gun. Confirm moist hide is damp.
- Days 1-7: Offer appropriately sized insects in the evening. Note appetite, stools, and activity.
- Week 1-2: Establish light schedule. Spot-clean daily. Refresh water daily. Maintain moist hide media.
- Week 2-3: If eating well, begin short calm handling sessions (5 minutes).
- By day 30: Weigh the gecko. Note baseline weight and tail condition. Schedule fecal check if not done at purchase.
- Ongoing: Keep moist hide maintained. Quarantine any new reptiles 60-90 days.

Symptom Quick Reference

This is a practical triage aid, not a diagnosis. When in doubt, contact a reptile-experienced veterinarian.

What you see	Likely direction	First response
Thinning tail + weight loss	Possible Crypto / illness	Weigh; isolate; fecal + vet soon
Leg tremble / soft jaw	Possible MBD	Verify heat + calcium; vet soon
Stuck shed on toes/eyes	Humidity / moist hide gap	Fix moist hide; no peeling; vet if tight
No appetite 1-2+ weeks	Husbandry or illness	Check heat; weigh; vet if continues
Clicking / wheezing	Possible respiratory	Check humidity/temps; vet

Daily & Weekly Routine

Print this page and keep it near the enclosure. Consistency matters more than perfection.

Daily

- Check warm-hide surface temperature with an infrared gun
 - Confirm heat mat / thermostat are working
 - Offer food on schedule for the gecko's age (evening preferred)
 - Refresh water dish
 - Spot-clean feces and uneaten insects
 - Quick visual check: eyes, toes, tail plumpness, energy
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Weekly

- Re-dampen or replace moist hide media
 - Deeper clean of water dish and high-contact surfaces
 - Weigh juveniles more often; adults periodically and log it
 - Inspect for stuck shed after a shed cycle (toes, eyes, tail tip)
 - Review feeder supply and gut-load quality
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Every 6-12 Months

- Replace UVB bulb on calendar if you run low-output UVB
- Annual wellness visit + fecal with a reptile-experienced vet
- Recheck thermostat accuracy and heat mat condition

Last changed / logged dates (write in):

UVB bulb replaced: _____ Next due: _____

Annual vet / fecal: _____ Next due: _____

Thermostat / equipment check: _____

Glossary

Belly heat - Warm surface temperature under or in the warm hide, measured where the gecko sits

Cryptosporidiosis (Crypto) - Serious contagious parasite; weight loss is a key warning sign; quarantine new animals

Dig box - A container of safe diggable substrate that lets the gecko dig without converting the whole floor

Dysecdysis - Stuck or incomplete shed of old skin

Enrichment - Opportunities for natural behaviors like hiding, hunting, digging, and exploring; never a substitute for correct heat or diet

Gut-load - Feeding nutritious food to feeder insects before offering them to the pet

Impaction - A digestive blockage, often linked to unsafe substrate or oversized prey

Metabolic Bone Disease (MBD) - Bone and muscle problems caused mainly by inadequate calcium balance and/or related husbandry gaps

Moist hide - A snug hide with damp media that creates a local humidity pocket for shedding

Thermoregulation - Moving between warm and cool areas to control body temperature

UVI - UV Index; a measure of UVB strength at the animal's level

This care package was compiled from BeastlyFacts research and practical husbandry standards.

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Disclaimer: This package is for educational purposes and is not a substitute for veterinary care. Handle critical health decisions with a qualified exotic veterinarian.

No external links are included in this document.
